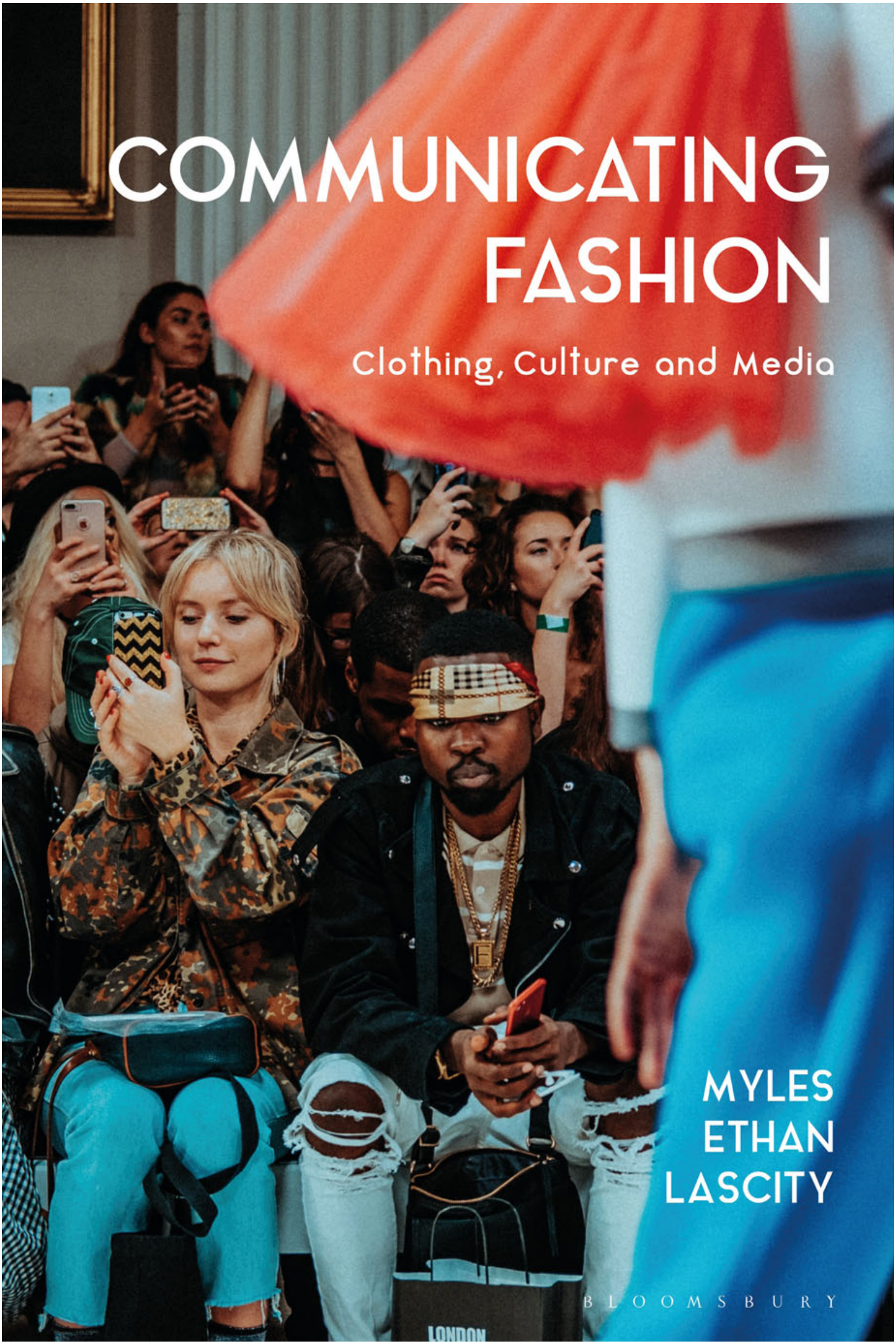

COMMUNICATING
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# 8

# *Digital Communication, Social Media, and Mediatization*

The now-classic Amy Heckling film *Clueless* is remembered for introducing the world to snappy catchphrases like "Whatever!" and "As if!" and memorable actors Brittany Murphy and Stacey Dash. However, one scene in the film that seemed rather fanciful has come to be a bit more predictive.

For those of you not in the know, *Clueless* was a 1990s retelling of Jane Austen's *Emma.* In it Cher, played by Alicia Silverstone, is trying to make her way through high school with her friend Dionne (Dash). Cher lives a relatively charmed life taking care of her high-powered lawyer father since her mother's passing. Like most high schoolers, Cher is concerned about getting her driver's license—even though she's a terrible driver—and interested in dating college men who she deems more mature than the "boys" in high school. Cher and Dionne decide to transform newcomer Tai (Murphy) and hijinks ensue as Tai's popularity eclipses Cher's leading to a turf war. Without giving too much away, there's a happy ending that borders on incest, but is rather sweet if you don't think about it too hard.

However, early in the film when Cher is getting ready to go to school, she enters her large, walk-in closet and she sits in front of her desktop computer, which helps her choose her clothing for the day. After scrolling through her options of tops and bottoms, she settles on a outfit only to be told "Mis-Match!"

when she hits the "Dress Me" button. Eventually, the computer suggests Cher settle on the yellow plaid outfit, with a pair of white Mary Janes with a slight kitten heel and thigh-high stockings—which the computer displays on a photo of her. Thankfully, the computer got it right since the outfit is now a 1990s movie icon.

However, more to the point, this scene was intended to be seen as overly extravagant to down-right fantasy, but today it seems like it might be coming to pass. Now, the Echo Look from Amazon allows users to take photos in different outfits and its algorithm will tell you which outfit "looks" better based on "fit, color, styling and current trends."[1] And, it's not just digital cameras: Uniqlo's San Francisco store includes a mirror that allows customers to change the color of the clothing they are trying on and captures a 360-degree image of them, while a mirror at Neiman Marcus allows you to take photos wearing different sunglasses and compare them side-by-side. Amazon has a patent for a mirror that allows you to try on virtual clothing, a step toward solving fit issues in online clothing retail.[2] It's easy to see how something that was far-fetched in the 1990s has now come to pass.

However, digitalization and technology didn't have to be so dramatic to greatly influence the fashion industry. Developments in communication technology from laptops and smartphones to blogging and social media have greatly shifted both personal communication and the media. This chapter will explore the ways technology has changed communication and the fashion system, revisiting some of the themes discussed in previous chapters. After exploring the history of the web, this chapter will look at how the digital communications reshaped ourselves and how we communicate with each other, before exploring its effect on the media industries and how it altered the landscape of advertising, branding, and retailing. Taken together, it's possible to see how technological developments have had a lasting impact on fashion communication.

## Some History and Theory of the Web

The internet was first developed in the 1960s and 1970s for military purposes: the idea was to have an interconnected communication system that was

dispersed and could continue to function in the event of a catastrophic attack.[3] Broadcasting, which at the time was the predominant way people could communicate with a group over long distances, was dependent upon physical towers to communicate, so if something happened to that tower, communication would be severely restricted. For example, during the attack on the World Trade Center on September 11, 2001, broadcast antennas were destroyed when the North Tower collapsed leaving local stations without a way to get their signals out. While both cable and the internet were already in wide usage at the time, the impediment of New York's broadcasting abilities spoke toward the original fears.

The internet was originally developed by a consortium of universities, including the University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA), Stanford University, the University of California, Santa Barbara and the University of Utah, along with the Advanced Research Projects Agency within the US Department of Defense. What came from these was a packet-switching network, meaning that when information was sent through this network, it would be broken down into small "packets" of information which were sent via the quickest path. The receiving computer would then reassemble the information. While the early internet would be used by the government and universities during the 1960s and 1970s, it would take until 1989 for commercial networks to get onto the internet, led by CompuServe and America Online (now called AOL).[4]

The early internet was somewhat different than what we're accustomed to now, in that it was largely text-based and largely consisted of email and listservs. Even early computer operating systems were text-based and it would take until Windows 95 for the graphic interface to be widely adopted. (There had been earlier versions of Windows and Apple had a graphic-based operating system for Macintosh computers, but all were bit players.) Eventually, the European Organization for Nuclear Research, known as CERN, would help to develop the "World Wide Web," which would standardize web addresses and coding language. This would allow the development of web browsers and led to the "internet" we're accustomed to using today.[5]

In the 1990s there was significant interest and growth in the internet as search engines like Yahoo, Excite and Lycos, email providers like Hotmail, and

interest-driven space like the women's site iVillage dominated. Website building and blogging also grew in prominence: sites like Geocities, Tripod and Angelfire allowed users to build their own websites, while Live Journal and Xanga were dedicated blogging platforms. While many internet firms were successful and decided to go public (i.e. sell stock), many went bankrupt in what would be known as the "dot-com bubble" in the early years of the 2000s. Some firms consolidated after the bubble burst, while other firms like Google, Yahoo, eBay and Amazon would end up as the dominant internet sites.

However, in the 2000s there would be another revolution: social media. The simple social network site, Friendster, launched in 2002, and both LinkedIn and MySpace launched in 2003. This opened the door to the sites that still dominate the social media landscape like Facebook (originally launched for college students in 2004 and opened to everyone in 2006), YouTube (2005) and Twitter (2006).[6] There would be other hiccups along the way such as the check-

## *Seven Names to Know in Digital Fashion*

**Julia Wainwright (born 1957)**—American tech entrepreneur, Wainwright founded the online luxury consignment site, The RealReal, which authenticates and helps resell luxury goods. Wainwright had previously worked with the startup Pets.com, which went bankrupt, before founding The RealReal in 2011.[1]

**Scott Schuman (born 1968)**—After quitting his fashion career, Schuman became one of the earliest streetstyle photographers and started the blog, The Sartorialist, in 2005. Since then, he's expanded to Instagram and released a number of books, including one documenting fashion in India.[2]

**Imran Amed (born 1975)**—Canadian-British consultant-turned-entrepreneur, Amed is the CEO and editor-in-chief of the website The Business of Fashion, which he started in 2007. The site's profile was raised when it received $2.5 million in seed funding in 2013. It currently publishes fashion news and various industry reports, including the BOF 500 ranking the most influential people in fashion.[3]

**Jennifer Hyman (born 1980)**—American businesswoman, Hyman founded the tech startup Rent the Runway with partner Jennifer Fleiss.[4] The site allows customers to rent clothing individually or as part of a subscription service which has led to a host of more established retailers doing the same.

**Arielle Charnas (born 1987)**—Blogger-turned-influencer-turned-designer, Charnas is known for her brand Something Navy. Charnas first collaborated on a product line with US department store Nordstrom in 2017, where it reportedly sold $4 million one day, and later announced plans to develop her own, independent lifestyle brand.[5]

**Tavi Gevinson (born 1996)**—Young blogger who first created the blog Style Rookie in 2008 at age eleven. She would become a known commodity from her attendance at fashion shows and the creation of the online magazine, *Rookie*, which she founded when she was fifteen. *Rookie* closed in 2018.[6]

**Kylie Jenner (born 1997)**—Reality star-turned-businesswoman, Jenner first rose to prominence on the show *Keeping Up with the Kardashians*, which documented her famous family, including sister, Kim, and parents, Kris and Kaitlyn. Jenner used the show as a launch pad to become a successful social media influencer, and later created her own brand of makeup, Kylie Cosmetics.[7]

in-based Foursquare (now Swarm), the short-video-based Vine, and the anonymous geo-locator YikYak—all of which grew quickly in popularity only to fade shortly thereafter. Photo-based platforms including Pinterest (2009) Instagram (2010) and Snapchat (2011) would take off a bit later and are still in wide use as of this writing, as is TikTok (2016), the short video-based platform.

It's worth taking a brief pause here to explain the difference between social network sites and social media. Many of the sites we consider "social media" started out as social network sites that allowed users to create profiles and connect and communicate with their network.[7] However, as smartphone technology grew and these sites expanded and developed as publishing platforms, they helped build what we now call social media. Today, social media is generally understood to include social networking sites and other forms of internet-based media, which allow users to connect with others, produce content (in whatever form), communicate with others and customize their profiles.[8] We'll come back to some of these points in the following pages.

In many ways, the internet and digital communications are unlike any of the media that has come before it due to its flexibility and interactive nature. For example, Mark Poster noted that the internet is largely underdetermined, meaning that it can be used in a variety of ways. The fact that the "world wide web" became the dominant way for us to use the internet wasn't predetermined nor is it the only way for us to use it.[9] While many people might not have the

technical knowledge to run their own servers, it remains a possibility. For example, the peer-to-peer file sharing network such as BitTorrent (currently) and Napster (formerly) do not use the world wide web; neither do smartphone applications. Both the openness in communication and the new capabilities provided by social media would have a profound impact on the ways in which we communicate.

Given the internet's vast underdetermination, its development—along with subsequent development of smartphones, thus making the "internet" portable, and the "apps" for phones and tablets—has had wide-reaching implications for a variety of industries. At the same time, "the internet" has become something of a catch-all term for all of the technological, communicative and media changes that have taken place over the past three decades or so. As such, while the rest of this chapter will use the internet to refer to increased usage of computers, smartphones and related technology, keep in mind that, unlike previous forms of media, the internet cannot be neatly summed up as one thing since it enables us to do *a lot* of things!

## Updating Ourselves

In the early chapters of this book, we discussed how we come to know ourselves and how we use our appearance to communicate about ourselves. As such, it should come as no surprise that the internet had profound implications for the way we communicate. For example, theorists like Jenny Sundén and Tom Boellstorff have explored the internet as a sort of "virtual world" to see how we understand ourselves in that space. Sundén noted that, especially in the early days of the internet, users had to "type" themselves into existence,[10] otherwise they would not be known in that space. While that was certainly true for chat rooms and text-based applications, it remains true for things like social media—without creating a profile you don't officially exist in that network. Boellstorff took this a step further as he examined the avatar-based chat program Second Life and argued that what happens on the internet isn't all that different from what happens in the "real" world and, as such, used the terms "virtual world" for what happens on the internet and the "actual world"

to denote what happens in the physical world. Still, Boellstorff noted that within Second Life people have the ability to portray themselves in whatever way they want,[11] something that still has implications for social media, where we continually put our best foot forward.

Russell W. Belk, who earlier theorized that material possessions help create our "extended selves", added that our social media profiles and the things we associate with also become part of our identity. Rather than consuming items privately or getting rid of them once they have been consumed, Belk pointed out that we frequently leave a digital trail online.[12] Some of this we might have done willingly: our social media profiles are likely littered with pictures from nights out with friends, special events with family and any number of other things. These photos are a digital memory of the places we've been, the things we've done and the clothing we wore. At the same time, digital algorithms help to keep a memory of the products we've looked at and purchased, which can help offer up ads to us later. While this isn't the same public performance as we post on social media (even though there have been some failed attempts at publicizing our purchases), it still has the ability to inform and shape our future consumption.

Likewise, our social profiles have enabled us to see ourselves in new ways. One method in particular that has gotten a lot of attention is the process of "branding" yourself. Researchers including Alison Hearn, Jefferson Pooley and Alice Marwick have all written about this phenomenon in various ways. Hearn suggests that the idea of branding ourselves took place within various realms—e.g. both reality television *and* social media—and indicates a blurring of capitalistic practices and the construction of the self. The use of social media platforms to promote or "brand" ourselves creates somewhat unique demands on our time that other people are monetizing. The implications of this raise important questions with regard to labor, production and consumption, which we'll come back to later in this chapter.[13]

Rather than seeing the internet as a wide open space for creating and expressing oneself (as Sundén and Boellstorff suggest) or as a primarily money-making venture (as Hearn and Marwick suggest), Jefferson Pooley lands somewhere in between. He notes that social media pushes people toward a "calculated authenticity" whereby people are doing, saying and acting

in a manner to get others to like them. However, Pooley points out that this idea has long roots, citing Dale Carnegie's *How to Win Friends and Influence People,* which was published in 1936, as the epitome of this idea, but he also ties it to Erving Goffman's idea of performance[14] (which we talked about in Chapter 2). Played out on social media, Pooley argues that these platforms have forced a dichotomy between being authentically expressive and performing or branding ourselves. You may or may not spend a lot of time thinking about what you post to social media and what it makes you look like, but if you've ever done something "for the 'gram'" you've taken part in this strategic representation of yourself.

## Updating the Media

Beyond the changes to how to present ourselves, the internet and social media has revolutionized the way we understand the "media." Prior to the development of the internet—and as we've more or less discussed in the previous chapters—each type of media was good for one thing. Books were good for saving and sharing information. Newspapers and magazines were able to print in a more timely way, and magazines were able to use new photography and design techniques. Films were for long visual storytelling; radio for audio productions, and television had the timeliness of radio and the visual of film. However, the internet allows us to do all those things, and more. This is an example of what we call media convergence, where text, photographs, video and audio all live side-by-side.

Jay Botler and Richard Grusin called this process "remediation" and argued that the internet is "mediating" older forms of media. In this telling, each new medium attempts to make things seem more real, while minimizing the fact that it is a medium. The internet put text, video and audio together in new ways; the basis of this—written language, photos and videos—are still ultimately the same and the "new media" (e.g. the internet) was simply *re*mediating the old media forms. Botler and Grusin used Marshall McLuhan's line, "The 'content' of any medium is always another medium. The content of writing is speech, just as the written word is the content of print, and print

is the content of the telegraph." In short, this process didn't start with the internet and has been happening throughout history since art began to recreate the real world.[15]

Agnès Rocamora centered her attention on fashion blogs and explored both their hypertextual nature and their remediation. Hypertext—the ability to link within one text to another—is one of the ways the internet is different than older media. Where a printed text could simply reference another article, the hypertext helps to make the story interactive, allowing us to click and visit another page. (Anyone who has used the internet has likely done this, whether or not you've called it a hyperlink.[16]) Rocamora goes on to note that fashion blogging involved significant amounts of remediation of the fashion press. Bloggers frequently discussed fashion magazines or, barring that, used similar styles of photography and representation in their work. At the same time the publishing industry began to use the content produced in blogs, remediating that content in print.[17]

Beyond the remediation, the computers and internet created two other major implications for the media: convergence culture and the fall of the gatekeepers. Convergence culture was coined by Henry Jenkins and refers to how we make sense of the world through various different means. Jenkins suggests that the internet is not going to replace older forms of media—just like television didn't kill radio, film or newspapers—but that media, and consumers, would adapt and use the internet in various ways.[18] Convergence culture allows consumers to produce and rework popular culture and better interact with those producing it. Further, the rise of the internet, blogs and social media was seen as a leveling of the media playing field, allowing everyone to participate in production. Shorthandedly, this has been chalked up to a "fall of the gatekeepers"—or a way to circumvent the cultural authority figures we discussed in Chapter 5. Some of the rosiest predictions suggested that bloggers would take the place of journalists and the mass media since it was so easy to self-publish.[19] While some of the news predictions have come true—just look at social media during a "breaking news" event—much of this also undermined the ability of media professionals to keep out the crazies and has opened the floodgates to conspiracy theories and misinformation.[20]

Brooke Erin Duffy closely examined the way women's magazines responded to these changes and noted that rather than remaining print-media specific, these organizations were harnessing the convergence culture to become brands. For those who worked for the magazine, the internet has forced them to develop a broader skillset beyond writing, editing or design. Now, magazine editors not only edit for a print edition, but might work on a digital edition, run social media feeds, blogs and apps. Likewise, as magazines transition to the web, their readership has changed as well. As we noted back in Chapter 5, magazines were largely predicated on developing a narrow, target audience, such as girls between the ages of 14 and 18 (*Seventeen, Teen Vogue, CosmoGirl*) or high-class travelers (*Condé Nast Traveler*) to any number of demographic, psychographic, geographic or interest-based groups. However, many online audiences are younger than their print counterparts and there is little overlap between print subscribers and online readers. Moreover, there is also the potential for online content to be picked up by search engines, requiring editors to consider search engine optimization (SEO), and providing the opportunity for anonymous audiences to find the work. Finally, Duffy noted that magazines have attempted to harness the power of their audience including creating blogger networks to which people could contribute content on magazine sites.[21]

## So You Want to be an Influencer?

While there are some blogs still around, much of the attention in recent years has moved onto *influencers*. You've likely heard the term tossed around, but maybe haven't figured out *exactly* what an influencer is. As journalist Taylor Lorenz points out, "influencer is a platform-agnostic term. It describes anyone who leverages social media to create a following and exerts influence over that following in order to make money."[22] While people like Kim Kardashian West, Kylie Jenner and Bella Hadid might come to mind when you think of an "influencer," the term would also include people like Arielle Charnas of Something Navy, and beauty blogger-turned-face-of-CoverGirl James Charles. Really, as Duffy points out, the media narrative has long been that "anyone" can become an influencer.[23] Too bad that's more fiction than fact.

Influencers stand at a unique intersection of personal identity and business considerations. As mentioned previously, social media has forced people into a type of contrived authenticity that can be "branded" in a certain way, while also appearing relatable. What gets lost in this process is that an influencer's content (whatever it might be) is time- and labor-intensive. While the exact process would depend on which platform people are involved in, for a budding influencer on Instagram the process might take the form of scouting locations, setting up photoshoots and lighting, taking the photos, editing the photos, writing captions, scheduling the post and then following up to interact with followers once the content is posted. And, despite myths to the contrary, this *isn't* just like posting to your everyday account. To be an influencer, you need to post content regularly and always be calibrating your posts for viewer interest.[24]

Various researchers have attempted to theorize labor in this sense, often with various terms and implications. To clarify, when people talk about "labor" they are usually referring to it in the Marxist sense where those without other resources sell their time in exchange for money. Traditionally, this has meant workers would produce a product that would be sold for more than its value in order to pay for the raw materials, the worker's wages and still have excess capital (i.e. money) for owners and/or upper management.[25] Until relatively recently, the production aspect—including its labor—was seen as one side of the equation and the people who purchased and used the goods that were made were seen as the "consumers" or those engaging in consumption. However, the internet and convergence culture has helped turn many people into both producers *and* consumers. This process is often referred to as the portmanteau (i.e. the combining of two words) prosumption and those who engage in it as prosumers.[26] Think about it: when we use social media, most of us are engaging in prosumption since we're likely posting text or photos while consuming that of our friends, families and anyone else we follow.

Outside of prosumption, there have also been various discussions of labor within this space. Since this labor is only producing communication, rather than a material good like a T-shirt or pair of shoes, it has been called immaterial labor.[27] Consider the following forms of immaterial labor:

- Entrepreneurial labor is where workers accept high-status jobs with low pay and potential personal financial risk for the possibility of future rewards. Working in fields like modeling and digital media usually comes with the understanding that the worker is an independent contractor working on their own, investing in their own careers, and not officially part of a larger organization.[28]
- Aspirational labor is where people produce content in the hope of getting paid in the future. Duffy found that those who engage in this type of labor—including bloggers and potential influencers—highlight authenticity, affective relationships and brand devotion.[29]
- Glamour labor is the work people do in all manners to make themselves seem "cool." This may be dieting, exercising or dressing in a certain way in the physical world, and posting statuses, photos and snaps to enhance your online persona.[30]

Regardless of how exactly we describe it, these various understandings of labor all suggest that we are working in an *unpaid capacity* with the hope of getting paid in the future. Some of this isn't new[31] and may seem commonsense to students who are already *laboring* in classes with the hopes of making money in the future. However, the key difference here is that while we participate within social media our work *is* being monetized. The firms behind Facebook, Twitter and TikTok are making money by selling ads against the content users create *for free*; this is how these companies have become billion-dollar firms.

The draw of becoming an influencer, of course, is that you get to do something you enjoy—and might even be doing anyway!—and get paid for it. Lorenz has pointed out that the number and types of influencers are ever changing and advertisers are spending millions of dollars to work with influencers to promote their products. While this has not escaped the attention of researchers, critics and even the government, some suspect there are deceptive marketing practices where influencers are being paid to support a product or brand, and keeping the payment a secret.[32] Beyond that, while some influencers *are* making money, the vast majority of social media users are not—even if they want to be! Those engaging in aspirational or entrepreneurial labor

may never see a financial return on their time commitment or even their monetary investments. And, as Duffy has pointed out, many of the people banking on this strategy won't have a fallback in the traditional career fields as everything is moving in a precarious and unstable direction.[33]

Finally, an inherent question of fairness is rippling across the employment world. Creative industries from modeling to acting to journalism and public relations are making assessments of people's social media when they apply for jobs. Therefore, many are expected to put in time and energy to develop their personal brand even before they are hired. This is, essentially, unpaid labor people are being expected to do before they are even to be *considered* for a job. Despite it not being obvious, someone is making money from this work—just not really the creators.

## Changes in Retail and Shopping

Where the internet and digital media has altered our personal communication and vastly affected the media landscape, it has had a pronounced effect on fashion advertising, branding and retailing. Some of this is directly related to the internet's communicative changes: brands need to be monitoring social media for customers' complaints and are often waiting for their "viral moment." Other changes have been somewhat indirect, including new retailers

### *Insight: Photo Manipulation in Advertising and Social Media*

The fashion and beauty industries have long been criticized for promoting unrealistic standards for people to live up to, as has been touched upon in previous chapters. And, while the art of photo editing has long roots, digital manipulation of photos has become easier to do—initially through computer programs like Adobe Photoshop and more recently with apps like Facetune and even now standard Instagram filters. This has the potential to change the way we understand the world, but also undermines how exactly we learn about the world. One such "hoax" has been a shark—originally shot for *National Geographic*—which has

"appeared" in places such as highways during hurricanes.[34] Still, much of the photo manipulation we see isn't fake in that way, just a gussied up version of reality.

However, US drugstore CVS took aim at digitally edited photos when it started a "Beauty Mark initiative" and a commitment to identifying visually altered advertising photos. Originally announced in 2018 with a target start date of 2020, the store partnered with beauty brands like Olay, L'Oreal and Maybelline to shoot and promote "realistic" images for in store and online.[35] As *Fast Company* noted, this was a step in a trend toward body positivity embraced by fashion brands like Aerie and spearheaded by Dove, and already legally required in countries like France.[36]

While editing our personal photos for social media may seem like second nature, some are suggesting that the process can cause body image problems. Dubbed "Snapchat dysmorphia," some doctors have suggested it is the cause of a rise in plastic surgery procedures. Some new filters aren't intended to make you look "better," but instead give you other means of self-expression. Some filters allow for metallic, glossy and even cyborg looks while other allow users to play with age and even gender—the last of which has been floated as therapeutic for trans people.[37]

coming onto the scene, largely made possible by the ease of the internet. In early 2019, one former startup, Amazon, became the world's most valuable company.[38] But, before we can get into the specific logistics, let's look at the big picture. The internet has made it possible to find, buy and even sell products around the world, in ways that were scarcely even imaginable a few decades ago.

Sociologist Sharon Zukin suggests that the ease of internet shopping has created a few paradoxes. The first is that the internet makes us shop more, despite its promises of making shopping easier and less time-consuming. While some facets of shopping (think: grocery shopping) have become easier as sites like Fresh Direct make it possible to purchase groceries, we spend more time on "shopping" for other products, like comparing models of televisions, reading reviews of cars or gadgets, or just browsing clothing sites. And, while Zukin wrote this before the rise of social media, think how easy it is for us to get pulled into "shopping" through advertisements on social media platforms and even through influencer posts. The second paradox is that the internet

doesn't help marketing.[39] This has been an ongoing concern and has led some researchers to suggest the internet has allowed customers to cut through advertisements and see the "value" at hand.[40] And, perhaps unsurprisingly, people haven't been eager to embrace brands and advertising, rebuffing those that ventured into the social media realm and leading to an ongoing discussion of how brand managers can engage online. There are also other factors at play including algorithms, which can influence the advertisements and social media messages we see.[41]

As mentioned above, fashion retailers are starting to better utilize technology to help people try on and shop for their clothing. Uniqlo, the Japan-based clothier, has used technology in various ways. In addition to its mirrors, Uniqlo stores include an online shopping portal (Figure 8.2) that allows customers to order products from its website that might not be currently available in the store. And, in an attempt to be accessible in places where stores aren't always possible, such as airports, Uniqlo has begun selling select clothing through vending machines. In truth, these are just the latest steps stores are taking to make shopping and purchasing easier for customers. More commonly, stores like Walmart, Macy's and J.C. Penney allow customers to purchase online and pick up the products in store, and many retailers allow purchases online with free shipping, with both free and in-store returns.

Beyond moving many brick-and-mortar retailers toward click-and-mortar retailing, the internet has also given rise to various internet-only (or, perhaps it's better to say *originally* internet-only) retailers. These often target niche markets or offer a niche product—like the shorts companies Chubbies and Birddogs. Both originally sold variations of men's athletic shorts aimed at post-collegiate, but not yet "adult" (read: boring) men. Journalist Sam Grobart named those brands along with the likes of Criquet and Untuckit "brotailers" as they were targeting young men frequently dubbed as "bros."[42] While the internet provided a space for these brands to gain traction and a following, many have leapt into the physical realm. For, example Untuckit launched in 2011 with the idea of selling men's shirts that are shorter and thus aren't expected to be tucked into pants. The brand, founded by two Columbia University alums, was online only until 2015 when it opened a New York City store, following by stores in Chicago, Los Angeles and San Francisco in 2016. And, suit makers




**Figure 8.2** *Online Instore. Kiosks inside some Uniqlo locations allow customers to find items online while physically in the store.*

Bonobos and Indochino, eyeglass retailer Warby Parker, shoe retailer Allbirds, and more all-purpose clothiers like Outdoor Voices and Marine Layer have also made the leap into physical retail.[43]

The internet has also helped revolutionize the very idea of *buying* at all. Consider Rent the Runway. Founded in 2009, the service focused on renting one-time formalwear for women who would want new outfits for different events. One of its founders, Jennifer Hyman, said her inspiration for Rent the Runway came from seeing her sister overspend on formal dresses and, when

questioned about it, her sister said since she was photographed in a dress and the picture was on Facebook she couldn't be seen wearing it again.[44] In short, Rent the Runway customers can select a garment—or garments—to rent for an amount of time, returning it when they are finished and receiving something new. The number of garments and the length of time customers can keep them depends on which level a customer buys into. The idea took off and spurred copycat offers from mass market brands as diverse as Vince, Ann Taylor, Express and Urban Outfitters, as well as inspiring the rental of furniture, home décor and small appliances.[45] While the renting of furniture wasn't new, per se (Rent-A-Center long predates this movement), Rent the Runway moved upmarket what had been seen as a déclassé practice, reserved for people with poor credit. These services were made possible by widespread internet and digital technologies, which allowed people to easily find and order items.

Another way the internet has helped change the face of retail has been with the growth of luxury consignment sites like The RealReal. While second-hand and consignment shops have been around for quite some time—they can be dated to Renaissance times,[46] if not before!—there has been a uptick in these stores in recent years. Sites like eBay spurred the buying and selling of all sorts of goods, and chains like Buffalo Exchange and Plato's Closet have been reselling clothing of all stripes. In these spaces, The RealReal has been a relative newcomer, not only reselling luxury goods, but also attempting to verify their authenticity. While the firm has been met with skepticism by some, and at least one lawsuit from Chanel, The RealReal's founder, Julia Wainwright, has suggested the site both introduces younger people to the world of luxury and helps to support the luxury market as a whole.[47]

One final way the internet has changed retail has been through a firm's ability to offer customizable products. While shoe brands like Adidas, Under Armour and Vans all provide customizations, Nike's offering dates back to 1999. Over time, even luxury brands like Burberry and Louis Vuitton have experimented with the idea; however, the process is costly for retailers and can take several weeks for delivery relegating the process to a niche market of people who care—and are willing to wait.[48]

## Mediatization, Algorithms and Apps

Beyond the specific ways in which the internet has changed communication there remains some broad changes digital communication has brought that are shaping everyday life in various ways. Perhaps the most notable has been increased mediatization, or how media permeates and alters our world.[49] Rocamora had applied this concept to clothing and designers to argue that it has altered fashion shows and retail. Like some of the aforementioned digital changes within retailing, Rocamora suggests that retail establishments are becoming more like websites, using displays and digital screens to recreate product offerings and choices one would expect online. Likewise, Rocamora has suggested this has also played out with brands beginning to produce their own niche, media content. For example, the luxury online retailer Net-a-Porter launched their own weekly magazine, *The Edit*, which replicated a traditional glossy magazine online and made it "shoppable" or able to buy products featured with a few clicks.[50] On the flip side, magazines like *Vogue* and *GQ* have also created looks that can be purchased from various shopping websites.

At the same time algorithms—the computer code that works to show users content they might want or like—have also shaped how we shop. Websites and applications as diverse as Facebook, Google and Netflix, and even advertisements you might not notice, use information about us to target content. Within social media we have some control over the algorithm: we select which accounts to follow and how often we engage with them, and can tell the algorithms to show us information less often or not at all. However, beyond that we don't have much of a say. Instagram (and Facebook and Twitter) show content based on what the algorithm thinks you'll like and interact with—whether or not it's accurate.

Tarleton Gillespie notes that algorithms have six dimensions through which they can shape culture. They are:

- Patterns of inclusion—what content is included within a set of information.
- Cycles of participation—what the algorithms intend to get users to do.

- Evaluation of relevance—how algorithms determine if information is relevant to users.
- Promise of objectivity—an implied assumption that the algorithm is impartial.
- Entanglement with practice—how algorithms respond to user actions.
- Production of calculated publics—how users understand themselves and those around them as displayed through the algorithm.[51]

On the whole, these elements are pretty self-explanatory and they could easily be mapped on to fashion: whether that is fashion media or shopping for clothes. Algorithms in social media and search engines determine what articles we might see from *Vogue* or other producers. At the same time, shopping algorithms—say from Gap or Amazon—determine what items to show you based on your purchasing or browsing habits.

More critically, though, algorithms should not be understood to be an objective application. They are constantly evaluating users based on the information provided to them and—at the end of the day—algorithms are biased in whatever way programmers create them. Think about it this way: in Chapter 5 we discussed how tastemakers help shape which stories are written and *how* they are written. Here, the coders who create algorithms determine whether you're provided with the information *at all*. This can lead to some delicate territory if coders aren't careful with what they are producing.[52] Likewise, this underscores the need for diversity among coders—a topic that has frequently been overlooked by the tech industry.

As the previous pages have showed, the internet and digitalization has transformed the way we communicate in untold ways. However, one of the latest developments has been the use of smartphone applications—"apps" for short. If you have a smartphone, you likely use apps all the time, but may not give them much thought. Developed by any number of developers and with some pre-loaded on our phones, apps seem natural to the smartphone environment. Still, they do present special considerations given the ease with which they can be attained and used (in comparison to more traditional software) and how they are created by third-party firms and distributed through "stores" moderated by the likes of Apple and Google.[53]

Again, apps have affected fashion in different ways—many of which have yet to be interrogated by researchers. However, media production companies have developed their own apps in order to entice users, even as more utilitarian apps, like Apple News, have begun offering magazine content to subscribers. At the same time, stores across the fashion spectrum have developed their own apps, which makes shopping easier. Finally, apps have given rise to a new set of casual gaming that has united fashion, gaming and celebrity culture. For example, in *Covet Fashion*, users create outfits using brand-name garments; these looks are then pitched against outfits created by other players. And, in *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood*, where users help turn themselves into A-list celebrities through jobs and appearances, players are able to "buy" clothing and accessories for their characters.